

HOW

DO YOU KNOW THIS IS A QUESTION?

The answer is at the end of the question. In English, the question mark is the punctuation symbol used in place of a period to let you know you are reading a question. No one knows who invented the question mark. Some speculate that when early Latin scholars had a query while writing out text, they added the word *questio* at the end of each line. Later, this was shortened to “qo” and eventually squished into a “q” over an “o” and finally the familiar squiggle. No matter who or how the question mark was created, no one can question how useful it is, along with all of the other symbols we use every day.

WHAT IS A SYMBOL?

Good question. A symbol is an object, picture, or word that represents something else. Your own name, for example, is a symbol for you. Sometimes, a symbol is something material that represents something less obvious. For example, the eagle is a symbol of the U.S.

WHY DO THEY WORK?

Symbols present information quickly and clearly, acting as visual shorthand for concepts such as “stop” and “go.” Imagine you are riding your bicycle, for example, and you pedal up to a sign that says, “Please could you begin braking now, as you are about to cross an intersection with traffic proceeding at high speed in the road parallel to you?” By the time you had read all of that, you would have been flattened by oncoming traffic. A red octagonal “STOP” sign tells you what to do in an instant.

WHERE DID THEY COME FROM?

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The earliest symbols were probably painted on the walls of ancient caves. Picture writing evolved as a way to record information without words. The first pictograms represented particular objects. For example, an ox drawing stood for an ox. More complex pictograms evolved to represent word sounds, and strings of pictures could be linked together to make a more complex script. Egyptian hieroglyphs, Sumerian cuneiform, and Chinese script are examples of this type of symbol.

